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Culture (OWC): [Shona \(FS05\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Southern Africa

Field Date: 1965-1971

Coverage Date: 1965-1971

Place Coverage: Zaka, Masvingo, Zimbabwe

Section Title(S): I. THE BOY'S AGE OF PUBERTY

There are other ceremonies one still hears about, but they are without any special symbolism and merely serve to publish the event of the first emission, and to make clear to the boy his new position in the community. During this period of his life the boy is also given more thorough instruction on sexual matters by some older members of the family such as, for instance, an elder brother and his wife. With the latter the youth is on special terms – the so-called “joking relationship”. It means that he may marry the woman if his brother dies. This particular relationship also allows intimacies which make a talk about sexual matters between the experienced woman and the youth easy.

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These instructions are mainly concerned with what the youth may do and what he may not do, what punishment he must expect for illicit relationships, and what the latter are.

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That the boys begin to masturbate is known, but the fact is accepted without comment and even welcomed, for it shows a normal development. Masturbation is even recommended as a means of releasing tension. The boy is advised, however, to cover the semen with soil or to catch it in a horn (a phallic sign) and then pour it away so that no-one can get hold of it for purposes of witchcraft. Masturbation between two boys is also considered unimportant by the Karanga since it never leads to genuine homosexuality and thus is simply regarded as a transitory phase.

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The youth's new social position is expressed by new duties and rights, and the symbols of childhood cease to be valid. He is allowed to touch the bow and arrows of the grown-ups and use them to go hunting. These weapons used to be taboo for the boy, for they are the symbolic signs of the sexual organs: the bow represents the scrotum, the string refers to the spermatic cord, the arrows stand for the man's semen and its spurting out in an orgasm. If a boy touched these implements before his first emission, he would render them unusable: the arrows would miss their aim just as his semen would be incapable of begetting children. That force within the boy which would make the seeds useless would here affect the functioning of the weapons.

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When a youth enters the age of puberty he may sit where the men sit, even if at first only to listen. Also, the freedom of his boyhood days is gradually reduced, he may no longer roam about as he likes but must start 76 working in earnest. He is also instructed as to his duties within the tribe and, especially, his behaviour towards elders and ancestral spirits. He learns the rules of hospitality and how to behave towards strangers. This also includes, for instance, lessons about his relations with future parents-in-law.

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